Overview:

After forming an interest in UX /UI design, I began to notice everyday interactions with various systems and their design. My research allowed me to unlock a perspective of design thinking, making every app, post, and platform I interact with undergo a personal user test.

I came across the app Untappd, a place to share and discover your favorite drinks, with an initial purpose of ranking and discovering beers. However, my friends who used the app often complained about the user interface, design, and workflows. Naturally, I had to download and run some personal tests, leading to this project redesigning Untappd's main page.

User Research

As a source of qualitative data, I sorted through Untappd reddit discussions, read countless app store reviews, and interviewed friends using the app to discover where the largest pain points are.

What the feedback revealed:

- The UI is basic, not modern, or engaging.
- It's hard to find recommended beers or trending beers.
- The ads are overwhelming.
- Lack of trust in recommendations or reviews
    - Users need more encouragement for detailed reviews
    - Recommendations cannot be trusted because of outliers with different tastes

To understand how I should design the new layout of the page, I first needed to understand what perceived value people are getting from the app. After using my sources of user research and reviewing the app's communicated purpose, I formed three main goals of use.

1. Community Engagement
    a. Users can connect with other users and friends, local breweries, and find local events.
2. Beverage Diary
    a. Users want a place to log their drinks, their notes, memories, and favorites.
3. Taste Preference Education
    a. Users want to understand what their personal beer taste preferences are, what drinks they would like in the future, and where to get these drinks.

(Quotes to support the above from users, do not edit the content of these and put them in quotation marks) :

- “I use it to give me a rough idea on how much i might like the beer by it's rating. “
- “I stopped using it to rate beers ages ago, but it’s helpful to find specific beers. “
- “By using Untappd. I can see what people are actual drinking at the pubs”
- “I love being able to select flavor profiles based on my personal interpretation, and tagging locations makes it a fun way to look back at my journeys through beer.”

With a community driven platform, user engagement feeds a positive feedback loop that leads to more content.

(create a graphic to showcase this cycle using the information below)
More users rank beers → Larger Sample Size of reviews → more accurate and applicable rankings for the general population → better references for user preferences and recommendations → more users ranking beers

The Problems

(show Initial Layout Page.png image, which shows the current layout of the app)

1. The UI. The main layout has a lot of different parts, organized in a way that overwhelms the user. It has cluttered ads, maps, beer for sale, events, badges, recommendations, and trending lists. There are black line gaps between sections, creating a noncohesive flow between sections. Additionally, the UI feels outdated, making the experience frustrating, vulnerable, and unvalued, suggesting the team hasn’t made the necessary updates to invest in a more pleasing, modern digital UI.
2. The UX. The main layout of the app is not encouraging maximum engagement. This consequently inhibits a better platform because of the cyclical nature of engagement creating a better user experience, as mentioned in the feedback loop referenced earlier. With recommendations and trending beverages at the end, it is not the main focus of the screen, when those features are the main focus of the app. Additionally, when a user first downloads the app, the call to action to begin ranking drinks is at the bottom of the page.(showcase this in the Call to Action Before.png)
    a. (create a diagram of this) The current user experience flows through this chart. Search option → merchandise ad → map feature showcasing breweries and bars → shop for purchasing beverages → ad → upcoming events → badges → trending drinks, places, top rated drinks, and top rated producers → recommended

(Quotes from users to support above:)

- “Only to track what I've tried. I don't rate beers, just record them.”

- “[I] realize ads are a way to fund growth, but the types of ads and frequency of them are annoying and sometimes disturbing ... .You've abandoned what used to be fun about this app, which was a way to connect with breweries and other beer lovers.”
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The solution

1. To redesign the cluttered, outdated UI:
    a. Limit the amount of on screen options to create a cleaner UI. Fewer choices simplify decision-making and give users faster access to the app's primary functions.
    b. Apply warmer brand colors, consistent spacing, and a clear layout hierarchy throughout.
2. To redesign the UX:
    a. Surface the features users care about most: drink recommendations based on past reviews, taste preferences, recently logged beverages, and easy navigation to the social/community side of the app.
    b. Add a call-to-action on the main page for first-time downloads, prompting users to start ranking beverages right away.
    c. Redesign the navigation bar, centering the call to action button to rank new beverages and simplifying the tabs.

Guiding Principles

1. Jakob’s Law: Users spend most of their time on other apps, so they carry those expectations with them. Placing familiar elements (search bar, navigation menu) where users expect them reduces cognitive load and keeps the interface intuitive.
2. Balance: Modules should be clean, symmetrical, and organized so users can navigate the app with minimal effort.
3. Trust: A simpler, modern UI increases user trust and makes the app feel more professional.
4. Hick’s Law: The more choices a user is presented with, the longer it takes them to decide. Limiting on-screen options at any given time speeds up decision-making and keeps the interface feeling simple rather than overwhelming.

Ideation

Using these guiding principles and solutions, I drafted multiple wireframes. They all include a call to action button to add a drink ranking and a navigation bar within the Thumb Zone for easy user access.

(showcase each with their pros and cons list below)
(Wireframe1): Pros: Strong visual hierarchy, grid scrolling format supports more information, and cutting off information encourages users to scroll. Cons: More visually crowded than others, more options could lead to higher user cognitive load.
(Wireframe2): Pros: Dominant focal point, inviting main screen, and simple layout. Cons: Allows for less information with the main hero taking up most of the screen.
(Wireframe3): Pros: Balanced, consistent design with uniform rows, allows for multiple highlights. Cons: Multiple points could feel less inviting when opening the app and the larger section seems like an afterthought below the list rows.
(Wireframe4): Pros: One unified section. Cons: Functions are not visually separated and could create user confusion and doesn't visually encourage users to scroll.

I decided to base my redesign off of a mix of Wireframe 1 and 2, allowing for a strong, welcoming visual experience when opening the app and increased information to encourage user engagement and scrolling.

My Final Design

In my final design, I've updated Untappd's discover/home page UX and UI, allowing for an easier, more enjoyable user experience.

Some general choices and why:

1. I opted for a more neutral color palette and rebranding the accent colors to a more subtle, professional gold and blue. This keeps the general colors for brand recognition, but allows for a less chaotic and bright interface. (show this before and after in Color Palette.png)
2. I changed the base font to a softer, more friendly font. This helps the app feel welcoming, approachable, and casual. (Show this before and after in Font.png).
3. When users are new to the app, I designed an obvious call to action, positioned on the main page right as the user opens the app. This prompts users to begin ranking drinks to unlock their taste preferences, gamifying the app with an "unlock" feature and showcasing educational taste preferences value in tanking drinks on the app. This also includes empty recommendations, encouraging the user to engage with the app to benefit from the recommendations. (Show in Call to Action After)
4. Eliminating buttons, such as the message button, to features that are no longer active. This stops the user from navigating to a dysfunctional page.

For the baseline user layout redesign (shown in Layout Ideas.png):

1. Included a top banner on the welcome page saying "Cheers [User's Name]". This welcome stays within the theme and purpose of the app and helps make the app more welcoming. This scrolls away as the user scrolls down and the search bar replaces it, pinned to the top for easy access.
2. A vertical scroll bar was added to the right hand side to give the user feedback in regards to their scroll positioning.

3. Below the navigation bar, there are buttons that stay pinned as the user scrolls for access to recently trending drinks, top drinks, trending places, and top places. These stay available regardless of position on the home page.
4. The opening home page highlights the user's taste profile, which updates as they continue to rank more opinions. This gives the user increasingly accurate information about their personal flavor preferences. Additionally, this can encourage users to compare flavor profiles, finding commonalities when sharing drinks. This fulfills the value needed for taste preference education, as well as community engagement.
5. The top recommendations for the user are highlighted on the main page as clickable cards. They also have a call to action button for the user to rank the beverage on the spot, encouraging increased rankings and engagement.
6. As the user scrolls to the second page, their recent rankings are highlighted. These are easily referenced if the user needs to recall a ranking and include their rating, any notes, and a photo icon of the beer. If the user includes a personal photo in their ranking, this can replace the generic beverage photo. This section also highlights a button to take less recent rankings in the chance they need to review all past rankings.
7. The events are highlighted below and can contain the time, location, and other details that might be necessary for the user to judge interest in attending.
8. When creating the nav bar design from my wireframes, I wanted the call to action (+) button to be central to the options and not cover any existing information on the app. Given this, I centered the button in the navigation bar and simplified the bar to include the following buttons: Home, Shop, Activity, and Profile. This navigation provides highlighted blue color feedback to the user to indicate what page they are currently viewing.
9. I added shadows to recommendation cards, encouraging the user to click for potential more information about the beverage or rank it immediately.

The impact

Effects of the improved UI:

- Increased trust and accessibility
- Increased potential for engagement
- More personalized user experience

(Data results in progress. Blank this section for now)

Takeaways:

1. Work in progress, more to come

Opportunities for Continued Improvement

Some ideas or features that could be added after proper research.

1. Ways to educate users on how beer is made, different kinds, in hopes that this insight could better inform their order decisions.
2. The badge features tries to gamify the app, but users find it annoying and interrupting the user flow. This could be replaced with a simple streak on a profile or creating competitions between friends/users.
3. The message feature has been retired, but the icon is still present on the app. When clicking it, the app explains message status is no longer active. I would recommend removing this to avoid unnecessary frustration, confusion, and pages on the app.
4. Create appearance changes for Light and Dark Mode, giving the user more control over their experience.
5. Use beer specific and consistent language. Some parts of the app reference “breweries” and others reference “producers”. I would consistently use “breweries”, helping the user in finding local breweries with simple and recognizable terminology.

Limitations

1. I understand my updated design does not currently include advertisements. These could be strategically added in to not overwhelm the user and complement the app features, rather than overtake.
2. Accessibility would be another consideration when implementing this redesign. The design should be responsive depending on font size, responsive layouts, screen reader tools, and other considerations.
3. When navigating the app, there should be sufficient feedback for the user to know when drinks were accurately logged or recommendations are updated.

Sources: https://www.reddit.com/r/beer/comments/184iqm4/untappd_sucks_as_an_app/
https://www.reddit.com/r/beer/comments/1myqulu/anyone_still_use_untapped/
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